

SCALE PRACTICE - HOW VS. WHAT

FROM DIGGING DEEPER VIDEO #46

Scale practice can be one of the most mind-numbing pursuits on earth if we let it. The trick is to understand that you are either practicing a "what " (ie. a new scale that you don't quite know), or a "how" (ie. a scale you know, but now you are working on HOW you are playing it). Scales serve many different purposes. Be sure that you know what you are practicing at any given time. What is your goal for these five minutes of practice? Be intentional. Focus.

Here are some good "hows" to think about when you are practicing. NOTE: don't kid yourself into thinking you can do four or five of these at once. Focus. One, maybe two.

- 1) Timbre/Tone - As you move up and down the instrument, is your tone consistent? The actual sound of your instrument. Does it get brighter or darker? Does it become thin up high? Are there fret buzzes, or inconsistent pitch? Listen hard!
- 2) Volume - Like #1 above, are you playing evenly, or are some notes sticking out due to volume unevenness? This can be caused by finger technique, air quality, breathing issues, poor fingerings and much more.
- 3) Even Technique - It's possible to play more or less in time, but with uneven technique. Are your fingers moving perfectly evenly? Every note of that scale?
- 4) Good Time - Are you playing in time? This is very important, and different from #3 above. It's possible to have very good technique, but to play out of time. They are different.
- 5) Moving Key To Key In Time - Once you finish one scale, move to the next scale in the sequence you are using IN TIME. Music moves from measure to measure, chord change to chord change, in time. Have your practice "mimic reality." Practice moving in time.
- 6) Articulation - This is a great way to add spice, groove, interest and direction to our scales and scale practice. There are a million different articulations to experiment with. Here is a great one for jazz . . . Off Beat Articulation, in this example on a G Bebop Scale.



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